

AMERICAS TECHNOLOGY: IT SERVICES

3Q Earnings Preview: Expect macro pressures to result in unchanged guidance; sentiment remains weak, but off the lows

Macro uncertainty takes upside off the table; sentiment remains weak, but off lows

We expect 3Q26 results to be broadly in line with the Street, with 2026 guidance remaining relatively intact at a sector level. However, we would expect company commentary to reflect the extension of tepid bookings activity in the quarter following deferred client decision-making starting in April-May since the beginning of the Mideast conflict. Given the tepid bookings activity we see, we would expect companies to begin to manage 2027 revenue growth expectations lower – resulting in modest downward revisions to 2027 Street estimates. However, we believe the most structurally bearish investor sentiment on the group has moderated somewhat, in light of the modest rebound in the stocks from the lows at a sector level, and given Accenture's solid report last week.

In this context, we see relative upside for IBM, which we see recovering some lost business which resulted from the deferral of mainframe and other Software deals out of 2Q given shifting spending priorities. Conversely, we see relative downside risk for more discretionary-exposed names such as GLOB, given the impact of macro weakness on several of Globant's verticals including professional services, travel, and media.

Tactical Ideas: We see modest upside for IBM, downside to out-year for GLOB

IBM (Buy) – We see modest upside to Street for the quarter, with no change to the company's downwardly-revised guidance for 2026. We see potential for two upside catalysts in the quarter: (1) better-than-expected Software results in the near term as we believe the company has been able to close a majority of the mainframe deals which pushed out of 2Q; (2) a potential acceleration in Consulting revenue in 2H given the impact of prior bookings converting to revenue.

GLOB (Neutral) – We expect no upgrade to GLOB's guidance for 2026, as we believe short-term visibility remains relatively solid. However, we expect muted end market demand trends to extend into 1H27 given the ongoing pressure in select verticals such as professional services, travel, and media. As a result, we expect 2027 estimates to potentially be revised lower until current macro pressures abate and visibility improves.

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IBM (Buy): Expect guidance to remain intact with slight upside into year end as slipped deals convert

Exhibit 1: IBM – Summary of GS vs. Street estimates

Financials (\$ mn)	3Q26E			2026E			2027E		
	GS	Street	GS/Street	GS	Street	GS/Street	GS	Street	GS/Street
Software	7,562	7,609	-0.6%	32,046	31,987	+0.2%	34,757	34,353	1.2%
Consulting	5,406	5,357	+0.9%	21,493	21,400	+0.4%	22,434	21,816	2.8%
Infrastructure	3,581	3,589	-0.2%	16,004	15,950	+0.3%	15,321	15,746	-2.7%
Other	187	196	-4.4%	761	791	-3.8%	769	791	-2.8%
Total Revenue	16,766	16,791	-0.1%	70,464	70,296	+0.2%	73,521	72,876	0.9%
Y/Y (cc)	4.2%			4.4%			4.3%		
Gross Margin (non-GAAP)	59.0%	59.1%	-13 bps	59.7%	59.6%	+9 bps	60.1%	60.0%	+1 bps
Pre-tax Income Margin (non-GAAP)	19.1%	19.2%	-2 bps	19.7%	19.7%	+5 bps	20.5%	20.4%	+1 bps
Net Income (non-GAAP)	2,726	2,734	-0.3%	11,841	11,768	+0.6%	12,805	12,638	1.3%
EPS (non-GAAP diluted)	\$2.85	\$2.86	-0.5%	\$12.40	\$12.33	+0.6%	\$13.35	\$13.14	1.6%
FCF (adjusted)	1,665	3,441	-51.6%	15,969	15,957	+0.1%	17,166	17,132	0.2%

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Visible Alpha Consensus Data

Setup heading into the print: We think investor sentiment on IBM has begun to recover somewhat following the company's 2Q guide down, as management commentary on conversion of slipped deals has been constructive. For the stock to move higher, we think management will need to deliver modest upside in Software and reiterate its 2026 revenue guidance, despite overall softness in consulting demand.

Our view on key metrics and our estimates: Our estimates are largely in line with the Street for 2Q, and we see room for modest upside through year-end given the 2Q reset in Software and Mainframe. For 2026, we expect IBM to reiterate its guidance for 4%-5% in constant currency revenue growth (we model 4.2% CC growth or \$70.46 bn vs. the Street at \$70.30 bn), along with a roughly neutral FX impact (down from 0.4% prior). We also expect IBM to reiterate its guidance for an increase of ~\$1.0 bn or more in free cash flow in 2026 (we model \$16.0 bn vs. the Street at \$15.9 bn). We think investors will remain focused on Software performance given last quarter's Transaction Processing miss, the ongoing Confluent integration, and expectations of double-digit growth in Red Hat in 2026. At the same time, we expect updated views on Consulting outlook given management expectation of modest acceleration in 2H26 given strong backlog, which we believe is especially important in light of Accenture's solid commentary.

Items on the call that could move the stock: (1) Recovery in Transaction Processing, plus Software mix and growth – A recovery in Mainframe and Transaction Processing deals slipped out of 2Q, plus a reiteration of lowered 6%-8% Software growth could improve investor confidence; **(2) Consulting revenue and bookings** – 3Q Consulting revenue trends and bookings could provide visibility into the sustainability of a recovery; **(3) AI** – Positive commentary on AI bookings and ARR growth could be a sign that IBM's organic AI investments (WatsonX) and AI partnerships are nearing meaningful revenue accretion.

Estimates: We maintain our 2026/27 EPS estimates of \$12.40/\$13.35.

Price target: We maintain our 12-month price target of \$270, which is based on 20X our one-year forward EPS estimate. Downside risks: 1) cyclical headwinds in software, 2) slowdown in consulting, 3) AI bookings deceleration, 4) dilutive M&A.

CTSH (Neutral): Expect steady growth, with sustained momentum in Financial Services

Exhibit 2: CTSH – Summary of GS vs. Street estimates

Financials (\$ mn)	3Q26E			2026E			2027E		
	GS	Street	GS/Street	GS	Street	GS/Street	GS	Street	GS/Street
Total Revenue	5,642	5,643	-0.0%	22,201	22,191	+0.0%	23,340	23,264	0.3%
Y/Y (cc)	4.6%			4.7%			5.0%		
Gross Margin	33.4%	33.6%	-25 bps	33.3%	33.4%	-7 bps	33.8%	33.6%	+3 bps
Operating Margin	16.3%	16.2%	+8 bps	16.1%	16.0%	+4 bps	16.4%	16.3%	+10 bps
Net Income	666	668	-0.4%	2,666	2,659	+0.3%	2,836	2,824	0.4%
EPS (non-GAAP)	\$1.44	\$1.47	-1.5%	\$5.75	\$5.76	-0.2%	\$6.35	\$6.35	0.0%
FCF (adjusted)	911	975	-6.6%	2,884	2,572	+12.1%	3,054	3,042	0.4%

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Visible Alpha Consensus Data

Setup heading into the print: We believe investor expectations have improved somewhat in light of peer Accenture's solid report and outlook, although we note investors remain cautious on the group given ongoing macro uncertainty. We expect growth to remain muted in the medium term, supported by strength in Financial Services and partially offset by macro headwinds impacting portions of Insurance.

Our view on key metrics and our estimates: Our estimates are broadly in line with the Street for 3Q and 2026. For 2026, we expect Cognizant to reiterate its guidance for 4.4% - 5.9% in constant currency growth (we model 4.7% CC growth or \$22.2bn, which is in line with the Street). We expect investors to focus on the impact of AI-led efficiencies on gross margins trends to offset pricing pressure and the size and scope of AI engagements.

Items on the call that could move the stock: (1) FY27 outlook – We expect investors to probe management on metrics (organic growth, booking trends, and macro impacts) that will affect the company's 2027 outlook; **(2) Gross margin trajectory** – Investors will focus on the execution of Project Leap and its impact on margin expansion in FY27, as well as the sustainability of AI-driven efficiencies to offset pricing pressure and improve the productivity of new campus hires. **(3) AI** – Investors will focus on Cognizant's ability to expand customer adoption of AI engagements and establish an early leadership position in the emerging agentic BPO market, which management believes could expand from roughly \$1tn today to \$5-6tn over time and drive growth medium term.

Price target: Our 12-month price target is \$70, which is based on 11X our one-year forward earnings estimates. Upside risks: 1) uplift in segments under pressure; 2) higher book-to-bill ratio; 3) margin expansion. Downside risks: 1) further demand slowdown; 2) dilutive M&A; 3) margin compression.

EPAM (Neutral): Expect macro uncertainty and execution challenges in the US to drive muted growth

Exhibit 3: EPAM – Summary of GS vs. Street estimates

Financials (\$ mn)	3Q26E			2026E			2027E		
	GS	Street	GS/Street	GS	Street	GS/Street	GS	Street	GS/Street
Total Revenue	1,423	1,418	+0.3%	5,672	5,654	+0.3%	5,809	5,848	0.7%
Y/Y (cc)	2.0%			2.7%			2.4%		
Gross Margin	31.8%	32.1%	-34 bps	31.2%	31.5%	-26 bps	31.2%	31.6%	-45 bps
Operating Margin	16.2%	16.1%	+18 bps	15.8%	15.8%	-2 bps	16.1%	15.9%	+16 bps
Net Income	177	175	+1.2%	689	686	+0.5%	719	713	0.9%
EPS (non-GAAP)	\$3.43	\$3.40	+0.9%	\$13.20	\$13.14	+0.4%	\$14.00	\$14.08	-0.5%
FCF (adjusted)	460	322	+43.0%	836	519	+61.1%	687	618	11.2%

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Visible Alpha Consensus Data

Setup heading into the print: We believe investor positioning remains negatively biased given ongoing macro headwinds, a softer discretionary spending environment, and recent execution mis-steps. We think expectations are low as the stock has underperformed peers in recent weeks (down ~8% over the past month), and we expect growth to remain muted in the medium term as the Americas segment continues to underperform given go-to-market execution challenges, partly offset by strength in Financial Services and Life Sciences in EMEA.

Our view on key metrics and our estimates: Our estimates are roughly in line with the Street for 3Q and FY26, as we expect softer demand for EPAM's core offerings of application implementation and consulting in the near term. For 2026, we expect EPAM to reiterate its guidance for 2.0%-3.0% in constant currency growth (we model ~2.7% CC growth or ~\$5.7bn, which is in line with the Street). We also model positive FX impact of ~1.3%. We expect investors to remain focused on demand trends in North America, and whether AI-led modernization programs can offset ongoing weakness in legacy service offerings, supporting a re-acceleration in growth.

Items on the call that could move the stock: (1) **Medium-term outlook** – We expect investors to probe management on deal activity, client decision timelines, and demand trends that could impact growth in 2027; (2) **North America** – Investors will focus on progress in EPAM's North American go-to-market, and whether AI-led modernization programs begin to offset ongoing weakness in legacy service offerings; (3) **AI** – As AI begins to contribute incremental revenue, investors will focus on AI-native revenue as a percentage of the business and the pace of growth from here. (4) **Gross margins** – While management has expressed confidence in sustaining 2026 gross margins above 32%, we expect investors to probe management on the durability of those margins into 2027.

Price target: Our 12-month price target is \$100, which is based on 7X our one-year forward earnings estimates. Upside risks: (1) earlier-than-expected recovery in discretionary IT spending, (2) increased demand for AI-related projects, (3) stronger-than-expected deal conversion. Downside risks: (1) further demand slowdown, (2) dilutive M&A, (3) increased geopolitical tensions.

GLOB (Neutral): Expect flattish trends in the near term given idiosyncratic market exposures

Exhibit 4: GLOB – Summary of GS vs. Street estimates

Financials (\$ mn)	3Q26E			2026E			2027E		
	GS	Street	GS/Street	GS	Street	GS/Street	GS	Street	GS/Street
Total Revenue	611	613	-0.2%	2,446	2,447	-0.0%	2,526	2,504	0.9%
Y/Y %	-1.0%			-0.4%			3.3%		
Gross Margin	34.0%	36.8%	-276 bps	35.6%	36.8%	-122 bps	35.4%	37.1%	-18 bps
Operating Margin	14.7%	14.0%	+68 bps	14.5%	14.0%	+53 bps	15.9%	14.5%	+13 bps
Net Income	65	67	-4.0%	261	263	-0.6%	296	282	5.2%
EPS (non-GAAP)	\$1.49	\$1.50	-0.9%	\$6.00	\$5.90	+1.8%	\$6.65	\$6.26	6.1%

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Visible Alpha Consensus Data

Setup heading into the print: We believe investor sentiment toward GLOB is relatively downbeat after management lowered guidance for 2026 last quarter given the current macro backdrop, as well as Globant's meaningful exposure to the Middle East. The stock continues to underperform in recent months (down ~9% in the past month), suggesting expectations are low heading into the print, although potentially more constructive after peer Accenture's better-than-expected print. We expect Globant to reiterate its guidance for flattish growth in light of these headwinds as its front-end oriented practices lag, partially offset by tailwinds in its "AI Pods" business.

Our view on key metrics and our estimates: Our estimates are broadly in line with the Street for 3Q and 2026. For 2026, we expect GLOB to reiterate its guidance for -1.1% to +.3% in constant currency revenue growth (we model -0.4% CC growth or ~\$2.45bn, which is in line with the Street), along with positive FX impact of roughly ~0.7%. We think investors will be particularly focused on demand trends in the Middle East, the US, and in consumer-focused verticals (Media & Entertainment and Travel & Hospitality), as well as growth in GLOB's "AI Pods" business and customer willingness to adopt a consumption-based pricing model over traditional T&M pricing.

Items on the call that could move the stock: (1) 2027 outlook – We expect investors to probe management current bookings, demand, and mix commentary as the company shifts toward more AI, data, and cloud-related work; **(2) Regional performance –** We expect update commentary on the impact of geopolitical disruptions in the Middle East. **(3) AI Pods –** Investors will look for updates on the company's progress toward its previously outlined ARR targets by year-end and 2027 growth expectations, as well as incremental AI Pod wins and customer adoption trends.

Price target: Our 12-month price target is \$52, which is based on an 8X P/E multiple applied to our forward 12-month earnings estimate. Upside risks: 1) earlier-than-expected recovery in discretionary spending, 2) increased demand for AI-related projects, 3) stronger-than-expected deal conversion. Downside risks: 1) demand slowdown in unique verticals (e.g., media, sports, and other entertainment), 2) further revenue slowdown, 3) dilutive M&A.

TASK (Sell): Expect solid performance, but with near-term margin expansion unlikely

Exhibit 5: TASK – Summary of GS vs. Street estimates

Financials (\$ mn)	3Q26E			2026E			2027E		
	GS	Street	GS/Street	GS	Street	GS/Street	GS	Street	GS/Street
Total Revenue	302	304	-0.6%	1,234	1,237	-0.2%	1,283	1,306	-1.8%
Y/Y %	1.0%			4.2%			4.0%		
Gross Margin	35.0%	36.1%	-111 bps	35.2%	35.6%	-45 bps	35.2%	36.1%	-9 bps
Adj. EBITDA Margin	18.7%	18.5%	+20 bps	19.0%	18.9%	+9 bps	19.2%	19.4%	-2 bps
Net Income	29	29	+1.4%	125	124	+0.9%	134	135	-0.4%
EPS (non-GAAP)	\$0.31	\$0.31	+1.6%	\$1.35	\$1.34	+1.2%	\$1.45	\$ 1.43	1.0%
Free cash flow				131	124	+5.4%	123	119	3.7%

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Visible Alpha Consensus Data

Setup heading into the print: We believe investor sentiment has improved following an increase in FY26 guidance and 2Q revenue growth that ranked near the high end of the peer group. However, we think investors remain cautious on the group given ongoing macro uncertainty, headwinds at its largest customer (Meta), and concentrated exposure to the BPS market, which we view as increasingly challenged by rapid AI adoption.

Our view on key metrics and our estimates: Our estimates are largely in line with the Street for 3Q and 2026. In FY2027, our revenue estimates are ~2% below the Street as we believe TaskUs will continue to face revenue pressure from automation and cost optimization initiatives at Meta, while broader BPS demand remains challenged as AI enables customers to automate portions of traditionally labor-intensive workflows. We expect TaskUs to reiterate its 2026 revenue and EPS guidance following its guidance increase last quarter.

Items on the call that could move the stock: (1) Early color on 2027 outlook – We expect investors to probe management on items that could impact 2027 performance, including current bookings, the mix of growth from existing versus new clients, and growth in AI services as well as the ability of those contracts to offset weakness in legacy businesses such as Trust & Safety. **(2) EBITDA margins –** We believe investors will be focused on margin trends and guidance, as the company expects margin pressure from additional investments and the onshoring of AI services. **(3) Meta demand given AI rising impact –** We expect investors to focus on commentary regarding Meta's demand trends heading into 2027 and whether revenue growth can stabilize following recent declines, or potentially return to growth.

Price target: Our 12-month price target of \$7, which is based on 5X our one-year forward earnings estimates. Upside risks: 1) slower-than-expected development of AI to customer service tools, 2) stable demand for US-based headcount, 3) faster-than-expected demand recovery at the company's largest customer (Meta).

Disclosure Appendix

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We, James Schneider, Ph.D., Luya You, Liana Wadhvani, Anmol Makkar, Khalil Fenina and Marshall Wong, hereby certify that all of the views expressed in this report accurately reflect our personal views about the subject company or companies and its or their securities. We also certify that no part of our compensation was, is or will be, directly or indirectly, related to the specific recommendations or views expressed in this report.

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Disclosures

Rating and pricing information

Cognizant Technology Solutions (Neutral, \$58.17), EPAM Systems Inc. (Neutral, \$109.95), Globant SA (Neutral, \$35.75), International Business Machines Corp. (Buy, \$221.58) and TaskUs Inc. (Sell, \$8.08).

The rating(s) for Cognizant Technology Solutions, EPAM Systems Inc., Globant SA, International Business Machines Corp. and TaskUs Inc. is/are relative to the other companies in its/their coverage universe: ARM Holdings, Accenture Plc, Advanced Micro Devices Inc., Amkor Technology Inc., Analog Devices Inc., Applied Materials Inc., Broadcom Inc., Cadence Design Systems Inc., Camtek, Cognizant Technology Solutions, Credo Technology Group, EPAM Systems Inc., Entegris Inc., GlobalFoundries Inc., Globant SA, Intel Corp., International Business Machines Corp., KLA Corp., Lam Research Corp., MKS Instruments Inc., Marvell Technology Inc., Microchip Technology Inc., Micon Technology Inc., NXP Semiconductors NV, Nvidia Corp., ON Semiconductor Corp., Onto Innovation, Qnity, Qualcomm Inc., SanDisk Corp., Seagate Technology, SiTime Corp., Synopsys Inc., TaskUs Inc., Teradyne Inc., Texas Instruments Inc., Western Digital Corp.

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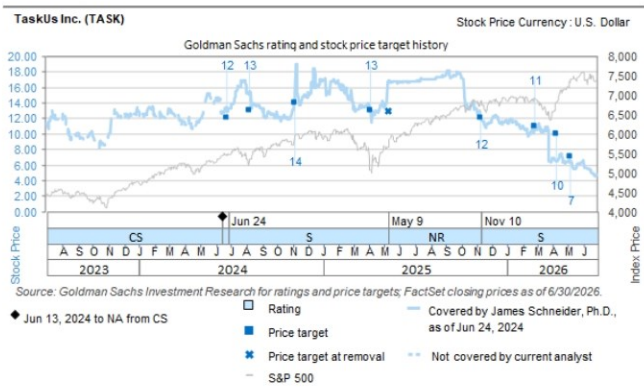
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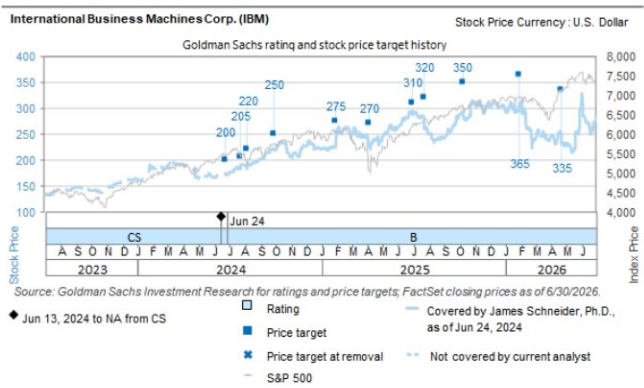
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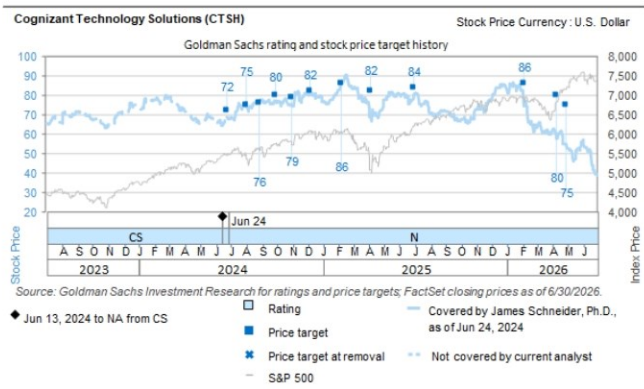
Price target and rating history chart(s)



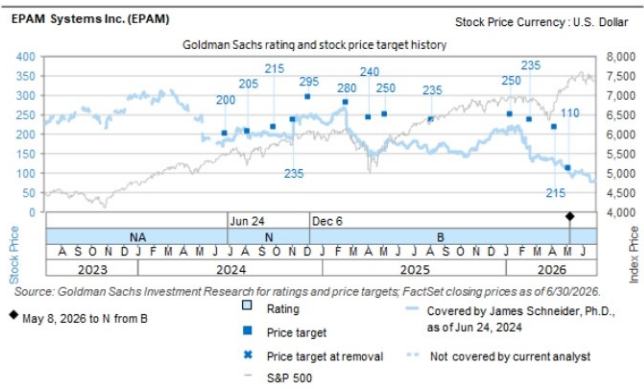
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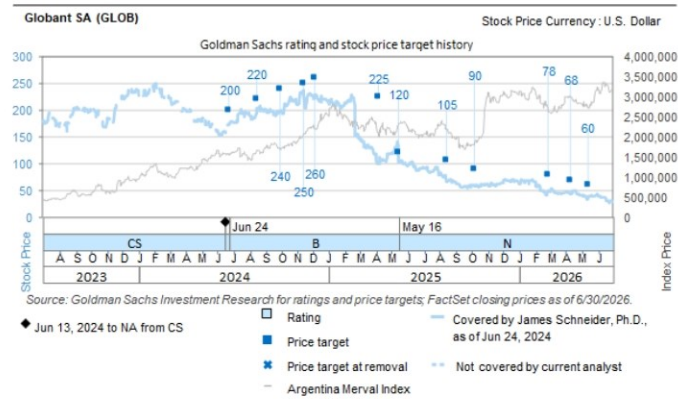
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Target price history table(s)

Cognizant Technology Solutions (CTSH)

Date of report	Target price (\$)	Closing price (\$)
29-Jul-26	70.00	55.97
29-Apr-26	75.00	54.70
10-Apr-26	80.00	57.92
04-Feb-26	86.00	76.71
01-Jul-25	84.00	80.44
06-Apr-25	82.00	68.74
06-Feb-25	86.00	87.09
06-Dec-24	82.00	81.15
31-Oct-24	79.00	74.59
30-Sep-24	80.00	77.18
27-Aug-24	76.00	77.15
01-Aug-24	75.00	76.31
24-Jun-24	72.00	68.68

Globant SA (GLOB)

Date of report	Target price (\$)	Closing price (\$)
13-Aug-26	52.00	40.99
15-May-26	60.00	38.91
10-Apr-26	68.00	43.26
27-Feb-26	78.00	49.76
08-Oct-25	90.00	59.41
15-Aug-25	105.00	66.46
16-May-25	120.00	101.47
06-Apr-25	225.00	100.55
06-Dec-24	260.00	229.73
15-Nov-24	250.00	203.29
30-Sep-24	240.00	198.14
15-Aug-24	220.00	194.37
24-Jun-24	200.00	173.67

EPAM Systems Inc. (EPAM)

Date of report	Target price (\$)	Closing price (\$)
06-Aug-26	100.00	93.07
08-May-26	110.00	99.23
10-Apr-26	215.00	122.47
19-Feb-26	235.00	139.16
12-Jan-26	250.00	211.82
07-Aug-25	235.00	157.74
08-May-25	250.00	179.71
06-Apr-25	240.00	144.67
20-Feb-25	280.00	225.07
06-Dec-24	295.00	245.45
07-Nov-24	235.00	232.92
30-Sep-24	215.00	199.03
08-Aug-24	205.00	191.16
24-Jun-24	200.00	183.09

International Business Machines Corp. (IBM)

Date of report	Target price (\$)	Closing price (\$)
23-Jul-26	270.00	206.65
23-Apr-26	335.00	231.08
29-Jan-26	365.00	309.24
08-Oct-25	350.00	289.46
24-Jul-25	320.00	260.51
01-Jul-25	310.00	291.20
06-Apr-25	270.00	227.48
30-Jan-25	275.00	258.27
30-Sep-24	250.00	221.08
07-Aug-24	220.00	186.80
25-Jul-24	205.00	191.98
24-Jun-24	200.00	175.01

TaskUs Inc. (TASK)

Date of report	Target price (\$)	Closing price (\$)
07-May-26	7.00	6.37
10-Apr-26	10.00	6.47
26-Feb-26	11.00	10.65
10-Nov-25	12.00	12.21
06-Apr-25	13.00	12.92
08-Nov-24	14.00	18.94
08-Aug-24	13.00	15.57

Date of report	Target price (\$)	Closing price (\$)
24-Jun-24	12.00	13.45

Price targets shown in table(s) are unadjusted for corporate actions.

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